

afterward, on the official pretext of negotiating a treaty, Cleopatra visited Rome. At the time, it was common practice to display captives in triumphs (victory parades), so during Caesar's triumph, Cleopatra may have witnessed the exhibition of her sister Arsinoë.

After Caesar's assassination, Cleopatra returned to Egypt. It is likely that she organized the assassination of her co-ruler, Ptolemy XIV, replacing him with her son, Caesarion (Ptolemy XV). For the next three years, Cleopatra was careful to avoid the power struggle that broke out after Caesar's death. Instead, she restored order and prosperity to her own kingdom, where she was a popular and efficient ruler.

By 42 BCE the Roman general Mark Antony and Octavian (the future emperor Augustus, see p.112) were in control of the Roman world. They split power between them, Antony taking charge of the eastern Mediterranean. He summoned Cleopatra to Tarsus (in modern Turkey), and once again, she set out to conquer a conqueror, dazzling the Romans with her style and guile.

Antony and Cleopatra

At Tarsus, Cleopatra and Antony became lovers, but passion had yet to overrule politics. Before long, Antony had rejoined his Roman wife, Fulvia, in Greece, where she had fled after a failed rebellion against Octavian in Italy. By 40 BCE Fulvia was dead, which enabled Antony to seal another peace deal with Octavian by marrying his sister Octavia. In the meantime,



Cleopatra's decree

This papyrus document is a decree exempting a Roman citizen, Publius Candidus, from paying tax. Written in Egyptian demotic script at the royal chancellery in Alexandria, it has a note by Cleopatra stating: "Thus it shall happen." The Ptolemies, of whom Cleopatra was the last, were Greek-speaking. She was the first and only Ptolemy to learn Egyptian, the language of her subjects.



Cleopatra and Isis

This limestone stele shows Cleopatra (left) breastfeeding her son while making an offering to the goddess Isis. She later claimed to be the reincarnation of Isis.

Cleopatra had given birth to twins: a boy named Alexander Helios (sun) and a girl named Cleopatra Selene (moon). In 37 BCE, Antony came

back to Egypt, and, while still wedded to Octavia, married Cleopatra. By the time he set off on an unsuccessful military campaign against the Parthians (see pp.122–23), she was expecting the baby she would name Ptolemy Philadelphus. Antony's next campaign, in Armenia, was victorious. His return to Egypt as a hero was followed by an event known as the "Donations of Alexandria." Seated on golden thrones,

Cleopatra and Antony proclaimed themselves as living gods—she Isis (see below) and he Dionysus/Osiris—and their children as the rulers of lands currently dominated by Rome.

After this, Octavian had no difficulty in persuading the Roman Senate to provide the means for an all-out war against Cleopatra, who was clearly determined to set herself up as a rival power. After her defeat by the Romans at the Battle of Actium, fought off the coast of Greece, she fled to Egypt with 60 treasure-laden ships, followed by Antony. Besieged at Alexandria, Antony killed himself, and Cleopatra, perhaps aware of her likely fate as the star of Octavian's triumph, also took her own life, supposedly with a poisonous snake hidden in a basket of figs.

Octavian honored Cleopatra's final request to be buried with Antony. She was 39. Her eldest son, Caesarion, was executed, but it is thought that the other children's lives were spared.

TIMELINE

- **c. 68 BCE** Birth of Cleopatra, third daughter of Ptolemy XII of Egypt.
- **55 BCE** Cleopatra's sisters Berenice and Tryphaena are killed for deposing Ptolemy XII.
- **51 BCE** Ptolemy XII dies; Cleopatra VII becomes queen of Egypt with her brother, Ptolemy XIII.
- **49 BCE** Cleopatra is banished by Pothinus, chief adviser of Ptolemy XIII.
- **48 BCE** Julius Caesar arrives in Egypt and defeats the forces of Cleopatra's sister Arsinoë and Ptolemy XIII; Cleopatra is restored to power with another younger brother, Ptolemy XIV.
- **c. 47 BCE** Gives birth to a son, nicknamed Caesarion by the people of Alexandria in acknowledgment of his supposed father.
- **46 BCE** Back in Rome, Caesar celebrates with four triumphs (victory parades), the most splendid of which celebrates his victory in Egypt and features Cleopatra's captured sister Arsinoë in chains.
- **44 BCE** Cleopatra leaves Rome for Egypt after the assassination of Julius Caesar. Ptolemy XIV is assassinated, possibly by Cleopatra, and replaced by her son Caesarion (Ptolemy XV).
- **42 BCE** Octavian (right) and Mark Antony win the Battle of Philippi. Antony and Cleopatra meet in Tarsus and become lovers.
- **40 BCE** Cleopatra bears twins, Alexander Helios and Cleopatra Selene. The father is Mark Antony.
- **37 BCE** Antony returns to the Middle East and Cleopatra funds his military expeditions.
- **36 BCE** Cleopatra has another baby by Antony, Ptolemy Philadelphus.
- **35 BCE** Cleopatra delivers funds and much needed supplies for Antony's defeated army in Syria; Cleopatra and Antony return to Alexandria in Egypt together.
- **34 BCE** Antony returns from a successful military campaign in Armenia and celebrates his triumph in Alexandria. Vast territories and exalted titles are assigned to Cleopatra and her children in a ceremony known as the "Donations of Alexandria," which alarms Rome.
- **33 BCE** In Greece, Cleopatra and Antony organize land and naval forces in anticipation of war with Rome.
- **31 BCE** Cleopatra and Antony lose the Battle of Actium, but manage to return to Alexandria.
- **30 BCE** Rather than be taken to Rome by Octavian as a prisoner of war, Cleopatra kills herself, allegedly by poisonous snake bite.



OCTAVIAN

"Plato admits four sorts of flattery, but she had a thousand."

PLUTARCH, IN HIS BIOGRAPHY OF MARK ANTONY, c. 75 CE

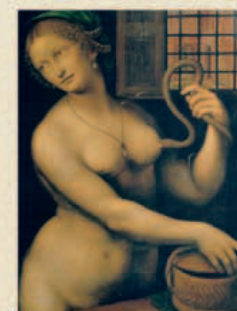
IDEA

THE CULT OF ISIS

Daughter of the earth and sky, and sister-wife of the god Osiris, Isis was the principal goddess of ancient Egypt. When Osiris was murdered by the god Set, Isis found his body and performed rites that would return him to eternal life. Then she retired to raise her son Horus, magically conceived from her husband's corpse, until he was old enough to avenge his father. While the myth of Isis may have arisen as a representation of the flooding of the rich plains (Isis) by the Nile (Osiris), the cult of the sorrowing wife and loving mother spread far beyond its place of origin. Isis was adopted as a patron divinity of travelers, and had particular appeal to women.



THE GODDESS ISIS



RENAISSANCE VIEW OF THE DEATH OF CLEOPATRA